

The Benefits of Multiple Boundary Spanning Roles in Purchasing

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Previous research has focused on purchasing managers' experience with role stressors and the negative effect of stress on job attitudes and performance. The potential benefits of having multiple responsibilities and a diverse role set have been overlooked. This study explored the relationship between purchasing managers' involvement in multiple boundary

SUMMARY

spanning roles and their perceptions of positive social outcomes related to work. The relationship of these social benefits to job satisfaction was also evaluated. The relationships were analyzed using structural equation modeling. The results indicated positive relationships between each variable in the model. The implications for recruitment, supervision, and job design are discussed.

INTRODUCTION

This study focuses on the potential benefits that purchasing managers can gain from their involvement in multiple job roles. Specifically, roles associated with external boundary spanning activities were assessed. This approach presents a contrast to previous studies that focused on the negative outcomes associated with the diverse responsibilities of and conflicting demands on purchasing managers (Michaels, Kumar, and Samu 1995). The results suggest that the characteristics of purchasing managers' jobs can contribute to their personal enrichment and job satisfaction. Suggestions are provided for designing and managing purchasing positions to maximize these outcomes.

PURCHASING MANAGERS' BOUNDARY SPANNING ROLES

The purchasing manager's position is a classic example of organizational boundary spanning. Purchasing managers are responsible for maintaining relationships with a variety of suppliers and must also respond to the needs of multiple constituents within their organizations. The definition of boundary spanning in this study focuses exclusively on purchasing managers' externally-oriented boundary spanning activities.

Six boundary spanning roles relevant to the purchasing managers' position have been identified (Adams 1980; Aldrich 1979; Alrich and Herker 1977; Ginter, Duncan, Richardson, and Swayne 1991; Jemison 1984; Katz and Kahn 1978; Miles 1976; Miles 1980; Oliver 1993; Renz 1981; Rosen and Adams 1974):

- **Gathering, Filtering, and Transmitting (Gate-keeping):** This set of three roles involves managing information relevant to the purchasing function. For example, a purchasing manager seeking to acquire a new type of material for the organization may *gather* information from several potential supplies. Next, the purchasing manager will analyze the information collected and *filter* out those bids that do not fit the organization's material needs or cost goals. Finally, the purchasing manager will *transmit* pertinent

information to internal constituents. The transmitting role further involves gatekeeping, the process of deciding what information to pass on, to whom, and at what time.

- **Transacting:** The transacting role addresses the core of the purchasing function and includes, for example, negotiating with suppliers to acquire materials and services for the organization.
- **Being Proactive:** The proactive role complements the transacting role and involves representing the organization to suppliers and establishing and maintaining supplier relationships.
- **Protecting:** This role involves protecting the organization's interests and guarding proprietary information. Forecasting of market conditions is an activity related to this role.

In addition to assessing involvement in each of the above boundary spanning roles, this study measured the intensity of boundary spanning. Specifically, respondents were asked how many hours they were involved in the different boundary spanning roles during a typical week and how many persons or groups outside the organization they had contact with on a frequent basis.

POTENTIAL SOCIAL BENEFITS

Social scientists have theorized why individuals faced with multiple, complex job roles choose to enter and remain in such positions. They have been interested in benefits, other than pay, that attract people to these jobs. The research suggests that the more roles an individual assumes, the more social benefits they are able to accumulate as a result of the variety and unique aspects associated with different role responsibilities (Sieber 1974). Attaining these social benefits should positively influence job satisfaction.

Six classes of social benefits, that may accrue as a result of taking on multiple role responsibilities, have been identified (Sieber 1974):

- **Role privileges:** Each boundary spanning role has its own set of distinct privileges.
- **Status security:** Difficulty encountered with performing one role can be compensated for by engaging and excelling in an alternate role.
- **Access to social perquisites:** These include having high "visibility" in the organization, receiving recognition for work accomplishments, and having meetings at fine restaurants.
- **Expert power:** Being sought out by others as a source of specialized job information.
- **Personality enrichment:** Having situations on a job that enrich one's personal experience.
- **Ego gratification:** Having others see one's job as desirable and attractive.

The respondents were asked about the degree to which they had obtained these different benefits, as well as how strongly they desired each of them.

RESEARCH HYPOTHESES

The following hypotheses were proposed:

Hypothesis 1: The number of boundary spanning roles engaged in by a purchasing manager will be positively related to the attainment of social benefits.

Hypothesis 2: The intensity of boundary spanning role involvement will be positively related to the attainment of social benefits.

Hypothesis 3: The attainment of social benefits will be positively related to job satisfaction.

A previous study involving retail purchasing managers provides preliminary evidence that the overall level of

The data suggest that the same set of roles that contribute to stressful outcomes, can also lead to personal gains that positively influence job satisfaction.

involvement in boundary spanning (similar to the measure of intensity used in this study) is positively related to social benefits (Keaveney 1988). The results also indicate that social benefits are positively related to job satisfaction. The current study sought to evaluate a similar set of relationships with a more explicit definition of different boundary spanning roles and expanded measurement of the social benefits construct. Relationships between boundary spanning roles and social benefits were also analyzed.

THE STUDY

Sample Characteristics

Each of the 529 members of NAPM's Transportation Group was sent a questionnaire along with a stamped return envelope. A total of 134 completed questionnaires were returned for a response rate of 25.3 percent. Job title classifications were adapted from a previous study (Carter and Narasimhan 1994). The majority of respondents indicated that they were purchasing managers or senior purchasing officers. The average respondent had been with his or her organization for about 10 years. Specific demographics of the sample are shown in Table I.

Measures

The questionnaire took approximately 15 minutes to complete. It included the following measures:

Boundary spanning roles. A 23-item scale describing the activities associated with each boundary spanning role was developed. Respondents were asked to indicate on a 5-point scale their involvement in each of the role activities (1 = Almost never; 5 = Almost always). The scale had a coefficient alpha reliability of 0.91. A coefficient alpha reliability provides an indicator of the degree to which a measurement scale is internally

consistent. Coefficient alpha reliabilities of 0.70 or greater are considered to be indicative of a scale that has items that agree with each other in meaning.

Boundaryspanning intensity. Respondents were asked to indicate the number of hours they engaged in boundary spanning roles during a typical week and how many individuals or groups outside the organization they had boundary spanning contact with on a frequent basis.

Social benefits. Respondents were presented with two, 10-item scales describing the different categories of social benefits. These scales were revisions of an existing scale (Keaveney 1988). On one scale, respondents indicated the degree to which they found each statement describing the benefits to be a desirable outcome (Desired scale), and on the other scale they indicated the degree to which each statement was true for their present job (Obtained scale). Each scale used a 5-point rating system (1 = Not at all; 5 = Definitely). The coefficient alpha reliabilities were 0.67 for the Desired scale and 0.73 for the Obtained scale.

Job satisfaction. An existing measure of general job satisfaction was converted to a 4-item, 5-point rating scale (1 = Strongly disagree; 5 = Strongly agree) (Brayfield and Rothe 1951). The revised measure had a coefficient alpha reliability of 0.87 for this sample.

Analyses

The hypothesized relationships were analyzed with a structural equation model using the EQS program (Bentler 1993). This type of analysis procedure tests the "fit" of a hypothesized set of relationships with the resulting data. Individual boundary spanning role-social benefit relationships were assessed using correlations.

PURCHASING MANAGERS' BOUNDARY SPANNING ROLE CHARACTERISTICS, SOCIAL BENEFITS, AND JOB SATISFACTION

Mean values for each of the variables are reported in Table II. The results indicate moderate to high levels of involvement in each of the specific boundary spanning roles, and in boundary spanning roles overall. Not surprisingly, the transacting role has the highest mean, followed closely by the proactive role. The intensity of boundaryspanning is also relatively high. Respondents have boundary spanning contact with close to two dozen individuals or groups on a frequent basis and spend nearly 40 percent of their time on the job engaged in boundary spanning. (Note: An average of 19.23 hours per week was spent engaged in boundary spanning. Responses to a separate question indicated that individuals in the study worked an average of 49.86 total hours per week.)

The results show a moderate level of attained social benefits. Expert power, however, was obtained at a fairly high level. Each of the social benefits was desired at a slightly higher level than it was obtained, indicating

some modest gaps in what respondents desired and what they actually received. Role privileges are the most desired social benefit and show the largest discrepancy from obtained levels. The overall job satisfaction of the respondents is moderately high.

The data demonstrated an adequate fit with the proposed structural model. The results for this original model, showing the strengths of the relationships between each variable, are displayed in Figure 1. Some slight changes in the model were necessary to obtain an optimal fit and are briefly explained below. Results for the final model are shown in Figure 2.

Hypotheses 1 and 3 were supported, but Hypothesis 2 was not. The frequency of involvement in different boundary spanning roles is associated with attainment of social benefits (Hypothesis 1). Social benefits have a strong positive relationship to job satisfaction (Hypothesis 3). However, when the initial model of hypothesized relationships was tested, the results showed a weak relationship between boundary spanning intensity and social benefits (Hypothesis 2).

Structural equation modeling procedures allow for removing some of the originally specified paths linking variables and replacing them with alternate paths in order to improve the model's fit. Such changes, however, cannot be made arbitrarily and must make theoretical sense in terms of how the variables in the model relate to each other. The removal of the path in the original model from boundary spanning intensity to social benefits, and its replacement with a path from boundaryspanning role frequency to boundary spanning intensity, led to a substantial improvement in model fit. This change is depicted in Figure 2. It appears that boundary spanning intensity is an indicator of boundaryspanning role frequency. That is, the more roles a purchasing manager engages in, the more time is required to perform them. The number of persons the purchasing manager interacts with also increases with each additional role.

Specific Boundary Spanning Role-Social Benefit Relationships

Correlational matrices of the relationships of specific boundaryspanning roles to the obtained and desired social benefits are presented in Tables III and IV, respectively. The gathering, proactive, and protecting roles have the most consistent significant correlations with individual social benefits. The social benefits most frequently correlated with involvement in different roles are role privileges, access to social perquisites, and expert power. A similar, but generally weaker, set of relationships is seen between boundary spanning roles and desired social benefits.

The transacting role, a major function of purchasing managers' jobs, is distinguished by only a single significant correlation with any of the obtained or desired social benefits. It may be that successfully negotiating

contracts with suppliers that are cost effective and meet the organization's needs is a routine expectation for all purchasing professionals. Negotiating is what purchasing managers are hired to do and is something that they should perform satisfactorily without expecting significant rewards (other than pay) from the organization.

It is also interesting that the proactive role, which is partner to many of the activities in the transacting role, has a much stronger pattern of relationships with the various benefits. A possible explanation for this relationship is that effective representation and strong relationship building skills have long-term, value-added benefits for the purchasing function and are thus a likely source of benefits and rewards. Suppliers who are treated well and dealt with honestly will likely want to continue the relationship with the buying organization.

CONCLUSIONS, LIMITATIONS, AND IMPLICATIONS

This study took a closer look at the boundary spanning roles performed by purchasing managers. The data suggest that the same set of roles that contribute to stressful outcomes, can also lead to personal gains that positively influence job satisfaction. Additionally, the results provided a view into the patterns of relationships between specific boundary spanning roles and social benefits.

The results should generalize to purchasing managers in other manufacturing industries. Two factors, however, limit the scope of conclusions that can be drawn from this study. First, a specific definition of boundary spanning was used and only boundary spanning behaviors directed at individuals outside the organization were examined. Therefore, the internal counterparts to each of these roles (e.g., interactions with the production, finance, and transportation departments) were not assessed. Previous research suggests that higher levels of role conflict and ambiguity are associated with these internal boundary spanning roles and may overshadow the social benefits that could be gained from them (Michaels, Kumar, and Samu 1995). Second, boundary spanning roles represent only a subset of the many roles for which a purchasing manager is responsible. The contributions of general supervision, training and development, financial management, and other roles to social benefits and job satisfaction were not assessed.

Implications for Purchasing Professionals

The results have implications for increasing purchasing professionals' job-related social benefits and improving their job satisfaction by expanding their involvement in different types of boundary spanning roles. The findings suggest that adding new roles to purchasing jobs could lead to job-related benefits and greater job satisfaction.

New roles should be appropriate for the position, and should fit the employees' qualifications to perform them. Fortunately, each of the boundary spanning roles that were examined have some relationship to purchasing

Table I

SAMPLE DEMOGRAPHICS — HIERARCHICAL LEVEL AND ORGANIZATIONAL TENURE

Hierarchical Level	N		
Vice President or Director of Purchasing	18		
Purchasing Manager, Senior Purchasing Officer, or Senior Buyer	81		
Buyer, Purchasing Agent, or Associate Buyer	24		
Other	11		
		Mean	Standard Deviation
Organizational Tenure (years)	9.95	8.85	

Table II

MEANS AND STANDARD DEVIATIONS OF BOUNDARY SPANNING, SOCIAL BENEFITS, AND JOB SATISFACTION VARIABLES

Scale/Subscale	Mean	Standard Deviation
Boundary Spanning Roles ^a	3.45	0.60
Gathering	3.43	0.74
Filtering	2.71	0.94
Transmitting	3.72	0.83
Transacting	4.05	1.19
Proactive	3.92	0.73
Protecting	3.15	0.80
Boundary Spanning Roles Average ^b	4.82	1.44
Boundary Spanning Hours ^c	19.23	11.78
Boundary Spanning Contacts ^c	23.84	23.95
Desired Social Benefits ^d	3.57	0.54
Role Privileges	4.13	0.85
Status Security	3.34	0.97
Access to Perquisites	3.43	0.67
Expert Power	3.87	0.80
Personality Enrichment	3.77	0.88
Ego Gratification	3.43	1.01
Obtained Social Benefits	3.09	0.60
Role Privileges	3.43	0.96
Status Security	2.99	1.09
Access to Perquisites	2.89	0.71
Expert Power	3.72	0.90
Personality Enrichment	3.33	0.96
Ego Gratification	2.96	1.15
Job Satisfaction ^e	3.87	0.76

^a Responses on a scale of 1 (= almost never) to 5 (= almost always)

^b Responses on a scale of 0 to 6

^c Responses on a scale of 0 to 99

^d Responses on a scale of 1 (= not at all) to 5 (= definitely)

^e Responses on a scale of 1 (= strongly disagree) to 5 (=strongly agree)

and are performed with at least a moderate frequency by most purchasing professionals. Caution should be exercised when adding roles that are outside the boundary spanning function or are less frequently associated with purchasing (e.g., new product evaluation) (Fearon 1989). Additionally, employees must be able to accommodate the added responsibilities within their existing jobs. As was discussed earlier, the intensity of boundary spanning (i.e., the hours worked, the number of contacts maintained) increases with the number of boundary spanning roles performed.

If the purchasing staff is already heavily involved in each of the boundary spanning roles previously discussed, an additional boundary spanning function might be considered. Respondents were asked to identify any boundary spanning roles that were not addressed in the survey. Some respondents suggested a role called *professional service*. This role includes activities associated with purchasing professionals providing expert knowledge to

outside groups. Examples include making presentations to local business groups, serving on committees in a professional association, and conducting training seminars. This role would be potentially beneficial to those employees with a strong interest in professional and educational activities. Additional research is needed to verify the significance of this role.

Another positive outcome of having an expanded variety of boundary spanning roles may be an increase in employee skills. The set of boundary spanning roles for a particular position could be associated with a distinct family of work competencies necessary for effective job performance. The organization's human resource managers could identify the individual knowledge, skills, abilities, and other characteristics that are involved in performing different types of roles and then establish appropriate training (Shankster-Cawley, Cawley, and Lee 1996).

The positive correlations between specific boundary spanning roles, obtained social benefits, and desired social benefits may create a platform for recruitment. That is, benefits whose attainment was correlated with involvement in a particular role, and that were also highly desired by individuals who perform the role, may be used to attract individuals to a position which incorporates this role. The incentive would be especially attractive if a frequently performed role is associated with a highly desired benefit. Two such relationships appear promising. Gathering information is strongly associated with attainment of and a desire for expert power and the proactive role is linked with attaining and desiring personality enrichment.

Finally, granting privileges related to the transmitting role may be an effective means for managers to provide incentives. The gatekeeping activities associated with the transmitting role (i.e., deciding what information to pass on to whom at what time) are privileges in and of themselves. Supervisors can curtail these privileges by requiring subordinates to report specific information to them at certain times. Relaxing the restrictions on reporting could be used as an incentive for the employee to enhance his or her performance.

Figure 1

ORIGINAL MODEL OF RELATIONSHIPS

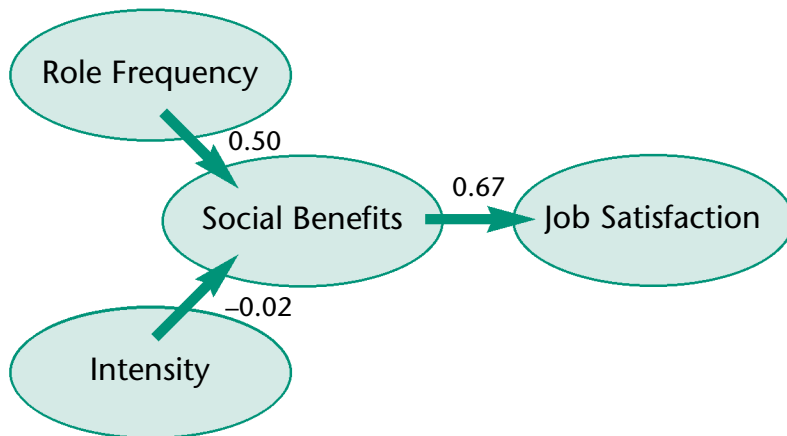
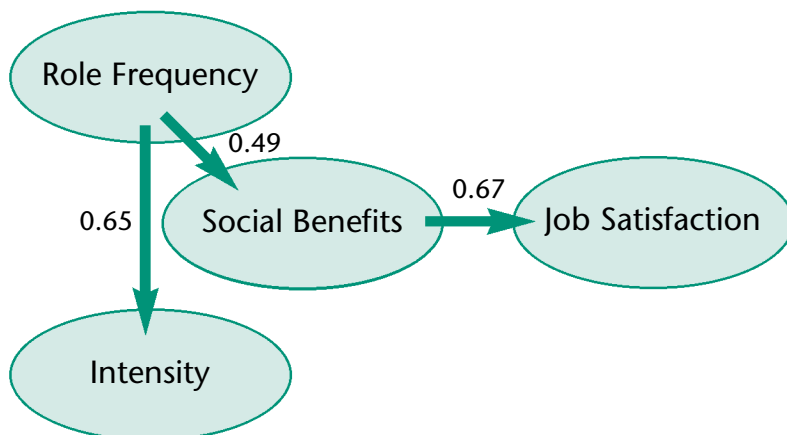


Figure 2

FINAL MODEL OF RELATIONSHIPS



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Table III

CORRELATIONS BETWEEN INDIVIDUAL BOUNDARY SPANNING ROLES AND OBTAINED SOCIAL BENEFITS

Activity	Role Privileges	Status Security	Access to Perquisites	Expert Power	Personality Enrichment	Ego Gratification
Gathering	0.18*	0.03	0.28**	0.42**	0.32**	0.22*
Filtering	0.23**	-0.08	0.34**	0.25**	0.08	0.16
Transmitting	0.28**	0.05	0.21*	0.27**	0.13	0.06
Transacting	0.14	-0.06	0.08	0.06	0.12	0.18*
Proactive	0.23**	-0.08	0.29**	0.27**	0.31**	0.14
Protecting	0.24**	-0.10	0.35**	0.30**	0.33**	0.21*

* Significant at p 0.05

** Significant at p 0.01

Table IV

CORRELATIONS BETWEEN INDIVIDUAL BOUNDARY SPANNING ROLES AND DESIRED SOCIAL BENEFITS

Activity	Role Privileges	Status Security	Access to Perquisites	Expert Power	Personality Enrichment	Ego Gratification
Gathering	0.15	-0.05	0.24**	0.33**	0.20*	0.06
Filtering	0.13	-0.17*	0.13	0.13	0.00	0.18*
Transmitting	0.23**	-0.01	0.19*	0.08	0.10	-0.01
Transacting	0.13	-0.11	0.00	0.01	-0.01	-0.07
Proactive	0.11	-0.12	0.27**	0.22**	0.24**	0.24**
Protecting	0.10	-0.08	0.20*	0.28**	0.23**	0.17

* Significant at p 0.05

** Significant at p 0.01